

Business Software Purchase — Small Business + SCM + 2 Warehouses + \$5k Budget

Executive summary — Small eco home goods business in Austin, 18 employees, 2 warehouses, 120 SKUs, 80 orders/day normal 200/day peak, 12 suppliers Mexico and US, current system QuickBooks Online + Google Sheets + Shopify + email. Trigger: 3 stockouts on top 5 sellers last quarter, \$30k tied in dead stock, spreadsheets failing across warehouses, Q4 rush October needs system live by September 1. Considered Cin7 quoted \$9k/yr over budget, Zoho Inventory procurement weak, Katana inventory light, Fishbowl. Budget \$5k hard cap \$8k perfect annually plus \$3k one-time migration, current \$400/mo apps need under \$700/mo total, 6 users. Must-haves: real-time inventory across 2 warehouses, barcode, order management Shopify to ShipStation, procurement PO tracking for 12 suppliers, cloud mobile dashboard, integrations Shopify/QBO/ShipStation, simple for staff.

The decision

Replace manual system of QuickBooks Online + Google Sheets + Shopify + email with single SCM cloud system under \$5k cap \$8k perfect annually plus \$3k one-time migration that provides real-time inventory across 2 warehouses, barcode scanning, automated order flow, procurement for 12 suppliers, mobile dashboard, integrations with Shopify, QuickBooks Online, ShipStation, for 6 users live by September 1 before Q4 rush, or keep current system and hire inventory help if no system meets budget, integration, and simplicity criteria.

Decision maker

Small business owner — 18 employees, 2 warehouses, 120 SKUs, 12 suppliers, manages operations, ops manager and 2 warehouse leads and 2 packers will use system daily, Shopify QuickBooks Online ShipStation current stack.

Situation

Current: Small eco home goods business Austin, 18 employees, 2 warehouses, 120 SKUs, 80 orders/day normal 200/day peak, 12 suppliers across Mexico and US, 6 users needed — owner, ops manager, 2 warehouse leads, 2 packing staff. Current system: QuickBooks Online + Google Sheets + Shopify + email with suppliers, manual cycle counts weekly, manual PO via email, no real-time stock across warehouses, no barcode scanning, no low-stock alerts.

Usage: Q4 holiday rush early October requires system live by September 1, can't have downtime in Q4, need same-day order processing without owner checking Sheets, supplier lead time tracking needed, mobile cloud dashboard for owner to check from phone, barcode for non-technical staff.

Financial: Budget \$5k hard cap \$8k if perfect annually including tax/fees, \$3k one-time migration okay, currently paying \$400/mo for QuickBooks + Shopify apps + ShipStation combined, need total under \$700/mo including new software. Considered: Cin7 liked but \$9k/yr over budget, Zoho Inventory cheap but procurement weak, Katana manufacturing focused inventory light, Fishbowl, friend suggestion keep Sheets + hire person.

Desired outcome

In 12 months: no stockouts on top 20 SKUs, inventory accuracy 98%+ without weekly manual counts, orders processed same-day without checking Sheets, POs automated to 12 suppliers with lead time tracking, cloud dashboard showing live stock from phone, stayed under \$5k/year plus \$3k migration, warehouse team scanning barcodes daily without complaints, handled Q4 rush of 200 orders a day without extra hires, QuickBooks stays in sync.

Prior experience

- QuickBooks Online + Google Sheets + Shopify + email — 3 stockouts top 5 last quarter, \$30k dead stock, Sheets broke with 2 warehouses

- Zoho Inventory trial — cheap but procurement tools weak, no supplier lead time
- No prior full SCM ownership — concerned about migration and supplier adoption
- Friend recommendation keep Sheets + hire inventory person — owner dislikes manual work

Priorities

- Real-time inventory across 2 warehouses with low-stock alerts and 98%+ accuracy without manual counts
- Order management automating Shopify to warehouse to ShipStation same-day without Sheets
- Procurement tools for 12 suppliers with PO tracking and lead times
- Cloud dashboard mobile access for live data
- Barcode scanning for receiving/picking usable by non-technical staff via phones
- Integrations with Shopify and QuickBooks Online and ShipStation — QuickBooks stays in sync
- Simple for 6 users — owner, ops manager, 2 leads, 2 packers

Constraints

- Budget \$5k hard cap \$8k if perfect annually including tax/fees, \$3k one-time migration okay, need total under \$700/mo vs current \$400/mo
- Timeline — must be live by September 1 before Q4 October rush, cannot risk downtime during Q4
- 6 users — not per-seat pricing that exceeds \$5k
- Non-technical warehouse staff — if complex they won't use it, barcode must work on phones
- Integrations required — Shopify, QuickBooks Online, ShipStation, or will fail
- 2 warehouses today, may add 3rd next year — need scale path

Options considered

- Keep QuickBooks + Sheets + Shopify + email and hire inventory person — avoids \$5k spend but doesn't fix 3 stockouts, \$30k dead stock, weekly counts
- Zoho Inventory — cheap within \$5k, good Shopify/QBO integration, but procurement weak for 12 suppliers lead time
- Cin7 — liked, real-time 2 warehouses, barcode, procurement, but quoted \$9k/year over \$5k hard cap \$8k perfect
- Katana — good for manufacturing but inventory tracking light for 120 SKUs 2 warehouses
- Fishbowl — inventory strong but cloud dashboard weak and QuickBooks sync issues reported

Tradeoffs

- Zoho vs Cin7 — \$5k vs \$9k for procurement strength for 12 suppliers, cheap but weak POs vs expensive but complete
- Cloud simplicity vs depth — easy for non-technical staff vs features needed for 200 orders/day peak and 2 warehouses
- Cost vs migration risk — staying under \$700/mo total vs paying \$3k migration and risking inventory error shutting shipping for days
- New software vs keep Sheets + hire — \$5k system gives real-time and automation but requires supplier adoption, hire avoids migration but keeps manual \$30k dead stock risk
- 2 warehouses vs 3rd warehouse scale — smaller tools fit 2 warehouses now but may not scale to 3rd next year

Risks and concerns

- Zoho procurement fails during Q4 and top 20 SKUs stock out anyway — no lead time tracking for 12 suppliers
- Cin7 at \$9k/year over budget and still needing custom work to connect QuickBooks Online
- Migration from Sheets losing order history or inventory wrong shutting down shipping for days before September 1 deadline
- Suppliers ignoring portal and team reverts to email POs — adoption failure
- Barcode scanning fails on phones or warehouse staff won't use — accuracy stays below 98%
- System can't scale to 3rd warehouse next year — need to re-buy

Unknowns

- Real migration cost — does \$3k one-time cover Sheets history and 120 SKUs across 2 warehouses with barcode setup?
- Real total cost — does under \$700/mo include Shopify, QBO, ShipStation, plus new SCM for 6 users or exceed?
- Supplier adoption — will 12 suppliers across Mexico and US use portal or require email fallback?
- Barcode hardware — do phones work or need scanners and does that fit \$5k cap?
- Integration proof — does Shopify to ShipStation to QBO stay in sync without Sheets checking?
- Support — what happens if inventory inaccurate during Q4 200 orders/day peak?

Decision criteria

- Real-time inventory across 2 warehouses with low-stock alerts and 98%+ accuracy without weekly manual counts, barcode scanning for non-technical staff
- Order management automates Shopify to warehouse to ShipStation same-day, 80/day normal 200/day peak, no Sheets checking
- Procurement for 12 suppliers with PO tracking and lead times, supplier portal adoption feasible
- Cloud dashboard mobile — live stock from phone
- Integrates with Shopify and QuickBooks Online and ShipStation — QuickBooks stays in sync
- Stays under \$5k hard cap \$8k perfect annually plus \$3k one-time, total under \$700/mo vs \$400/mo current, 6 users, live by September 1, scales to 3rd warehouse

Next steps

1. Export Sheets with 120 SKUs and counts per warehouse and last 90 days orders to verify 80/day normal 200 peak and \$30k dead stock list
2. Shortlist 3: Zoho Inventory, Cin7, and one mid option like Fishbowl or Katana that meets \$5k cap \$8k perfect and Shopify/QBO/ShipStation integrations and barcode
3. Demo with 6 users — test receiving with phone barcode, create PO for 12 suppliers with lead time, push Shopify order to ShipStation and check QBO sync
4. Get migration quote for \$3k one-time — does it include 120 SKUs 2 warehouses history and guarantee no downtime before September 1?
5. Get out-the-door pricing under \$5k cap \$8k perfect for 6 users and under \$700/mo total, contract for 3rd warehouse scale price, and supplier portal trial with 2 suppliers

Recommendation

Do not buy Zoho if procurement for 12 suppliers with lead time fails in test and risks Q4 stockout on top 20 SKUs. Do not buy Cin7 if \$9k/year exceeds \$8k perfect and total exceeds \$700/mo and needs custom QuickBooks work. Do not

buy if barcode fails for non-technical staff or integration with Shopify/QBO/ShipStation requires Sheets. Proceed only with single SCM under \$5k cap \$8k perfect plus \$3k migration that proves in demo: real-time across 2 warehouses, 98%+ accuracy, same-day order flow without Sheets, PO tracking for 12 suppliers, mobile dashboard live, barcode daily by warehouse team, QBO in sync, 6 users under \$700/mo total, live by September 1. If no single meets all, negotiate Cin7 down or consider keep Sheets + hire for Q4 and re-evaluate after rush.

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